

Identifying Solicitations

Finding fundable opportunities and making disciplined go/no-go decisions

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Session roadmap

A compact process for opportunity discovery, triage, and action.



Core question

What opportunity is worth your next 30–80 hours of proposal development?

Start with the solicitation—not the idea

A solicitation is a sponsor's written theory of what deserves funding.

What to extract first

Eligibility and required partners
Submission window and due date
Award size, duration, and limits
Required outcomes and review criteria
Restrictions, cost share, or special rules

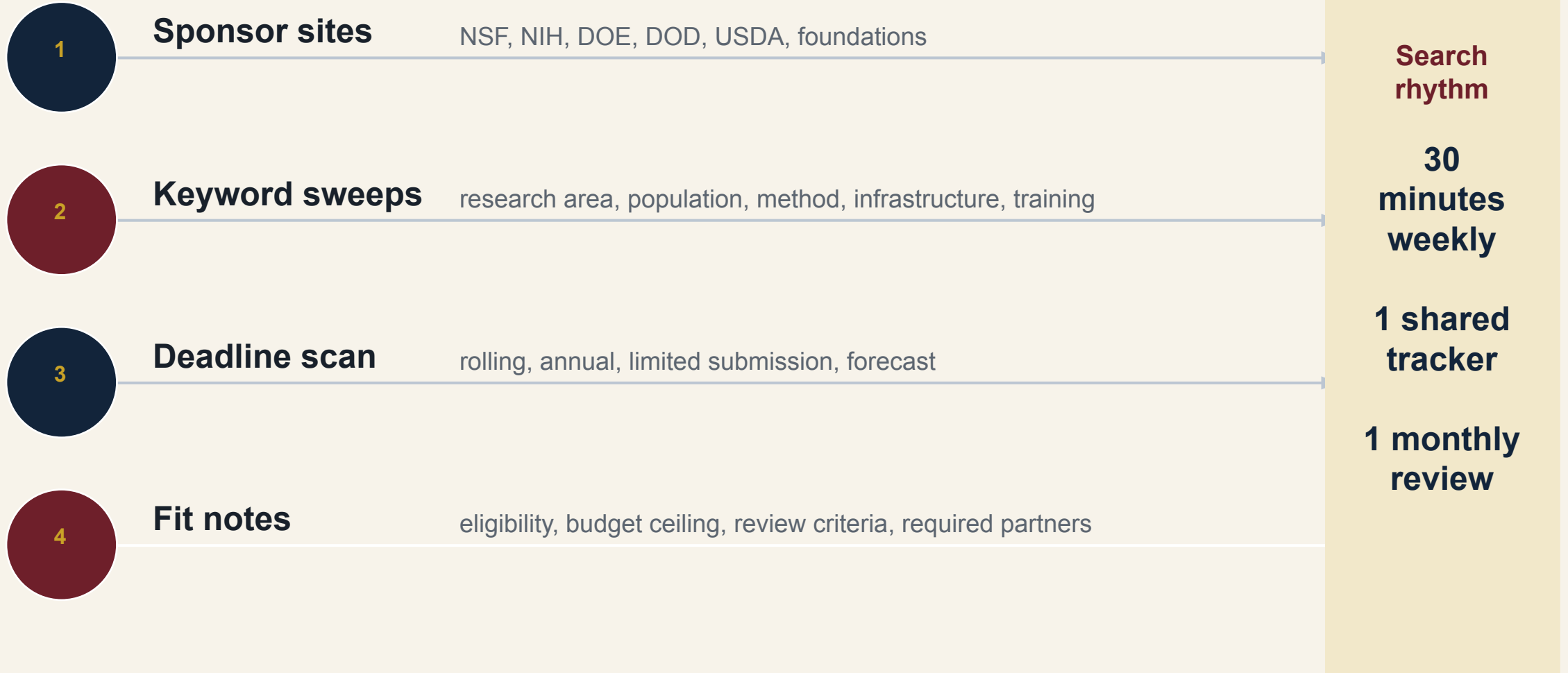
The fundability test

Your proposal becomes stronger when your idea is shaped by the solicitation's language, review criteria, and evidence expectations—not forced into them at the end.

Practical rule: read the solicitation before you build the proposal outline.

Manual search: build a disciplined discovery routine

Manual search works when it is systematic, not occasional.



Using AI to find opportunities: treat it as a scout

AI can accelerate discovery, but it should not replace source verification.



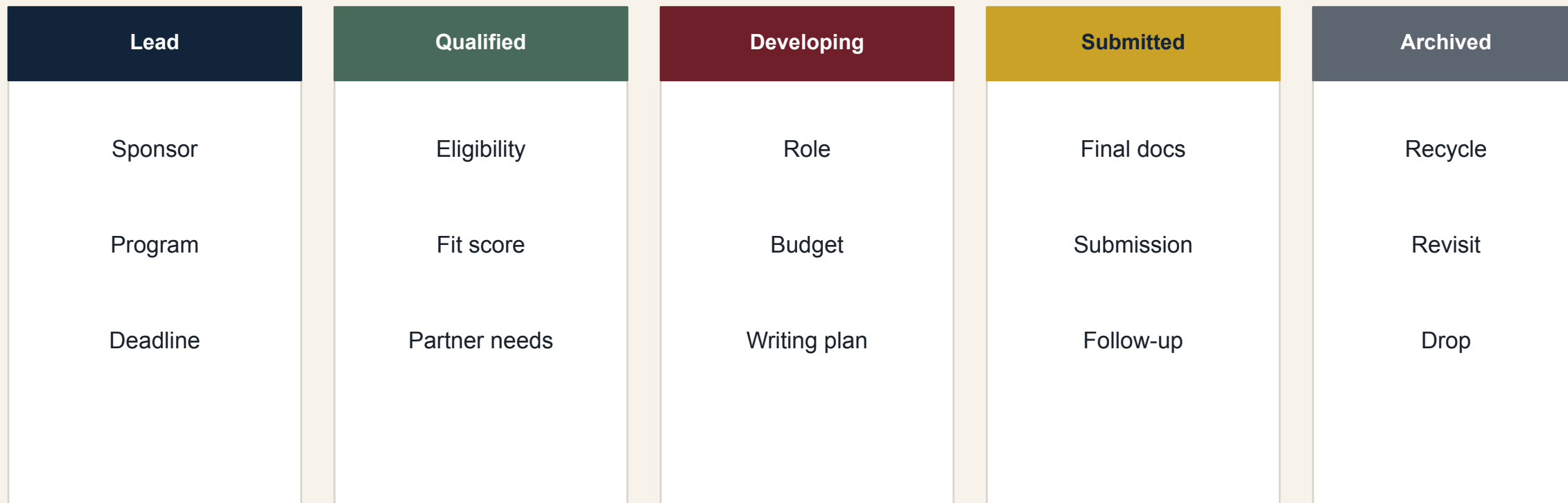
Prompt pattern

“Find grant programs for [topic], [career stage], [institution type], [budget range], [deadline window]. Return eligibility, fit rationale, due date, and official link.”

Verify every opportunity on the sponsor site
Use AI for breadth; use the solicitation for truth
Ask AI to summarize, compare, and flag fit risks
Keep “not interactive” tools limited to scouting, not final interpretation

Managing prospective solicitations: create an opportunity pipeline

A tracker turns random leads into accountable decisions.



Minimum tracker fields: sponsor, program, deadline, PI/CoPI roles, budget range, fit rationale, next action, owner.

Prospective roles: choose the role that advances the strategy

Role decisions should reflect contribution, career goals, and workload.

PI

Owns vision, coordination, sponsor relationship

Co-PI

Leads a core component with accountable intellectual contribution

Senior Personnel

Contributes expertise without full leadership load

Evaluator / Advisor

Adds credibility, feedback, or assessment capacity

Subaward Partner

Brings specialized infrastructure, population, or capability

Role filter

**Will this role
produce
credible
outcomes,
career value,
and a
manageable
time
commitment?**

Budgets and opportunity costs: the hidden go/no-go engine

A “good” budget funds the work without consuming the team.

Budget lens

- Personnel: student support, summer salary, release time
- Travel, participant costs, equipment, data, software
- Indirect costs, subawards, cost share, compliance
- Real administrative effort before and after the award

Opportunity cost lens

- What proposal, paper, course, or relationship gets delayed?
- Is the award large enough for the required lift?
- Can the team execute without reputational risk?
- Does the project create future funding leverage?

Key question: Is the award worth both the money and the calendar space?

Short-term versus long-term advantages

Some solicitations are worth pursuing because of what they unlock next.

Short-term advantages

- Immediate funding for students or staff
- Near-term publications or deliverables
- Pilot data and proof of concept
- Institutional visibility

Long-term advantages

- Builds a fundable research trajectory
- Creates sponsor relationship and credibility
- Positions larger center or collaborative proposal
- Develops infrastructure, data, or curriculum assets

Best cases do both: they solve a current constraint and create a future platform.

Recycling proposals: build reusable assets, not stale submissions

Proposal material should improve every time it is reused.

Reusable

problem statement, literature frame, team bios, facilities, evaluation logic, broader impacts

Must be tailored

review criteria, sponsor priorities, work plan, budget, outcomes, language

Never recycle blindly

old deadlines, wrong eligibility, mismatched aims, unedited partner roles

Create a proposal asset library with version control and “why it worked / why it failed” notes.

Alignment: test the opportunity against multiple goals

The strongest proposal decision has sponsor, personal, and institutional logic.



Ask: “Does this solicitation help me become known for the work I want to be known for?”

Availability: convert “interest” into a calendar reality

A go decision without available time is a risk decision.

Proposal lift estimate

Light
10–20 hrs

small supplement, short LOI

Moderate
30–60 hrs

standard single-PI proposal

Heavy
80+ hrs

center, multi-partner, complex budget

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- Block writing time before saying yes.
 - Identify who owns narrative, budget, letters, biosketches, and internal routing.
 - Require a deadline buffer for feedback and compliance review.
 - Use no-go when time constraints create predictable quality problems.

Decision-making: a simple go/no-go framework

A disciplined no can preserve capacity for a stronger yes.

Fit		● Does the solicitation match the project and review criteria?
Role		● Is the proposed role strategically valuable and credible?
Budget		● Does the award support the real work?
Time		● Can the team produce a competitive submission?
Leverage		● Does this create future research, partnership, or institutional advantage?

Decision rule **Go only when fit, role, budget, and time are all defensible.
Leverage determines priority.**

Activity: identify one program to submit to

Leave with a named solicitation, a tentative role, and the next action.



Working task

- Find one solicitation or program announcement
- Capture sponsor, program name, due date, award size, and link
- Write a two-sentence fit rationale
- Choose a prospective role: PI, CoPI, senior personnel, partner, advisor
- Make a go/no-go recommendation and name the next action

Output: one opportunity tracker row completed

Solicitation Selection Checklist

- ✓ Official solicitation reviewed
- ✓ Eligibility and deadline verified
- ✓ Role and team responsibilities clear
- ✓ Budget range and major restrictions understood
- ✓ Opportunity cost and calendar lift estimated
- ✓ Alignment with career, department, and sponsor goals confirmed
- ✓ Go/no-go decision recorded in tracker

Final thought

The goal is not more proposals.

The goal is better choices, stronger submissions, and a sustainable funding strategy.